

Handling Conflict at Work

Defuse, without fleeing or exploding

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Defuse, without fleeing or exploding

A disagreement that festers, a tension that sours the mood, a colleague you clash with: conflict at work is inevitable. The problem isn't the conflict itself, but how you go through it. Handled well, it can even strengthen a relationship.

This guide helps you understand your reactions to conflict, ease the emotion, and resolve it with concrete tools — without fleeing or steamrolling.

Your intention

A work conflict you'd like to handle better: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Your reaction to conflict

Facing conflict, each of us has a reflex: flee, submit, or attack. It was learned early — often tied to fear of rejection, abandonment, or a family model.

Knowing your default reflex lets you choose a different response.

Example

At the slightest disagreement, Sami went quiet then stewed. Understanding his fear of conflict helped him dare to speak when calm.

My conflict reflex

When conflict erupts, do I flee, give in, or attack? Where does the reflex come from?

What conflict stirs up

What fear hides behind it (rejection, injustice, loss of control)?

→ *My conflict reflex is learned — I can choose another.*

The thoughts that escalate

'They're doing it on purpose', 'I'm obviously right', 'it's hopeless'. These mind-reading thoughts turn a disagreement into war.

Questioning them opens the way to dialogue.

Example

Sure a colleague was 'sabotaging' her, Nia checked: he was just overloaded. The tension dropped.

Conflict journal

Note: my thought about the other · another possible explanation · what I actually know.

Reframe

Turn 'they're doing it on purpose' into a more neutral hypothesis.

→ *I don't read minds: I check before judging.*

Listening to understand

Behind every position is a need. Listening to the other (without giving up yourself) defuses more than being right. Separate the person from the problem.

Empathy isn't weakness: it's leverage.

Example

By simply asking 'what matters to you in this?', Léa turned a standoff into a discussion.

The need behind the position

For your conflict: what's MY need? what might THEIRS be?

Separate person from problem

Reframe the conflict targeting the problem, not the person.

→ *Behind the position is a need — listening defuses.*

Resolving concretely

Resolving conflict happens when calm, in private: speak in 'I', listen, seek a shared solution, and bring in a third party (manager, HR, mediation) if it's stuck.

A conflict handled well can strengthen the relationship.

Example

Rather than a curt email, Sofia suggested a coffee, spoke in 'I', and found a compromise. The collaboration resumed.

My preparation

Write: my 'I' message · what I want to understand from them · a possible solution.

My plan B

If dialogue fails, whom do I turn to (manager, HR, mediation)?

→ *When calm, in private, in 'I': a conflict gets resolved.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Handle it when calm, never hot — and in private, not in front of the team.
- Speak in 'I' (my feeling, my need), not accusatory 'you'.
- Really listen: paraphrase what they say before replying.
- Look for the need beneath the position ('what matters to you?').
- Aim for a shared solution, not a win.
- If stuck, bring in a neutral third party (manager, HR, mediation).

To fill in

Conflict journal

Date	My thought about them	Another explanation	My real need

My preparation

My 'I' message	The solution I propose

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Know my conflict reflex.

Week 2 — Question my mind-reading.

Week 3 — Listen for the other's need.

Week 4 — Resolve when calm, in 'I'.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The conflict I tackle:
- My 'I' message:
- The shared solution I propose:

TO CLOSE

Without fleeing or steamrolling, you can defuse.

Without fleeing or steamrolling. You seek the solution.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.